

bone of ideological contention as we currently understand it. Chanda is never Panglossian. He does not believe that globalisation is a seamless process; he points out the vast conflicts, anxieties, inequalities and vulnerabilities it generates. But this is a tiger that we cannot dismount without becoming something altogether different from what we are, something perhaps unrecognisable.

Chanda gives a good tour d' horizon of the issues at stake. But in the end this is the part where one wishes Chanda was less generous in his sympathies and stuck his neck out on a few issues. He argues that "calls to shut down globalisation are pointless, because nobody is in charge, but together we can nudge our rapidly integrating world toward a more harmonious course—because we are all connected". Fine. But a parallel story to this one would emphasise two things: given the conflicts inherent in globalisation that Chanda charts, what will determine its character? How will the conflicts amongst those whom globalisation impacts differentially get resolved? What will make the drivers of globalisation act more responsibly?

The second is the extraordinary fact that human beings have an extraordinary capacity to delude themselves, especially under the guise of self-serving narcissisms. Chanda is aware of this and regrets that we have not yet developed a consciousness that is commensurate with our globalised future. But what is going to be the strength of this anti-globalisation sentiment? It is one of the remarkable facts of human nature that it can deny it material and social embodiments and act against the logic of its own well-being. Countering these challenges will require more than recognition of the fact of globalisation. Perhaps the best argument for globalisation is the one implicit here: globalisation is the best expression of human nature, in all its variousness. To abridge it would be to abridge ourselves. ■



Caught in the Net

A philosophical take on Kerala's community of fishermen, Visvanathan's novel tracks their lives trapped in ideological turmoil

PHOSPHORUS AND STONE
by SUSAN VISVANATHAN
Penguin/Zubaan
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■ **By Geeta Doctor**

Is it time to declare a no-fiction zone in the troubled backwaters of God's Own Country? Every writer with a Kerala connection is diving into the ancestral pond and dredging up the dirt. The latest to fish in these waters is Susan Visvanathan. Not that she does not come with impeccable credentials. She has tracked the lives of the fishing community of Kerala trapped in the ideological turmoil that rapid economic progress has brought into their lives. She's also a writer of lyrical sensibility. In a seminal essay titled "Workers of the Sea", there is a riveting description of the "pregnant sea" at the onset of the monsoon, a time when the fisher folk leave the fish to spawn in a band of water, so as to replenish the ocean for the next season. The evocative piece

explains the tragedy of Kerala's fishing community, as greed and commercial fishing have destroyed these practices.

Which is what makes her latest work of fiction that trawls the same territory such a basket of contradictions. The narrator is a young girl called Magda, short for Mary Magdalena, who scrounges for her living by going down to the sea when the fishermen bring in the catch. She has a rich inner world that not only includes a familiarity with Gramsci and Fanon, but Hollywood stars and a truly execrable reference to the Aussie actor Russell Crowe, whom she finds in the shape of a krait rustling in her backyard latrine. Or as she puts it: "Luckily it rustled in time—rustle krait if not Russell Crowe."

There are more philosophical curiosities thrashing about on the beach along with Magda's romance with a man named Jesu. Somewhere along the way, there's also a pearl waiting to be found in a luminous interpretation of the story of Christ's resurrection. Visvanathan's readers will have to be content even if it's not a perfect one. ■

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